in waterfalls (drowning on land)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/79760126.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by n7punk

Summary

Catra has always hated water, and she has always hated showers, but she has never stood at the entrance of one scared of what could happen if she steps inside. Her mind knows it's nothing, but her skin is crawling on her shoulders, expecting hands to land on them and push her down beneath the water.
It has to just be this first one. It has to get better after this. She still doesn't know why Adora has forgiven her and she doesn't want to drive her away with her smell of all things. The problem is her body believes that will happen less than it believes Horde Prime will materialize in Darla's tiny bathroom.
(Or, Catra relearning her relationship with water)

Notes

This fic is part of the Thank You She-ra event to celebrate She-ra before it leaves Netflix, written for the week five prompt: Season 5.

Chapter 1: First Return

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The bathroom on Darla is small, compact and meant only for quick showers in the midst of a journey. It's not the ideal condition for a skittish showerer.

It's different from the Velvet Glove. She keeps telling herself that. That was wide and open and full of clones ready to do whatever it took to drown her. Another person couldn't fit in this shower with her. She'll be alone. No one is going to touch her. She can… she can get through this. She'll be fine. It will just be the normal amount of uncomfortable. Nothing will happen.

She has told herself this, maybe, a dozen times, standing outside of the shower and looking into the tiny shower stall next to the toilet. It looks pretty different from the Horde showers, the door running all the way to the bottom of the stall to keep the rest of the bathroom dry – what a novel idea – so that once she gets this over with, she can escape all the water. She just needs to get through it.

"Hey Catra?" a voice calls and Catra startles, whipping around to face the door. She quickly wraps her arms around herself as if to cover herself despite the fact she still hasn't taken off her "clothes" – Adora's underwear – and she has already walked all around the ship like this.

"I'm showering," she calls. She can't- she can't do this with a *time pressure* from someone else waiting to use the bathroom. She doesn't know she can do this at all. There's a moment of silence.

"You're hyperventilating," Adora corrects, immediately proving herself wrong, because the words make Catra hiss. She wasn't, anyway, and even if she were, Adora wouldn't have been able to hear it through the door. "I've got something for you," Adora adds.

Catra just stares at the door, arms tightening around herself. She can hear her own breathing, but that's- normal. She has really good hearing. Of course she can hear her breathing sometimes.

"I'm going to come in, okay?" Adora eventually says. Catra clenches her jaw, glaring at the door as she sucks in a hard fought breath and holds it, waiting. She only seems like she's breathing heavily when Adora opens it because she waits too long trying to be polite and Catra needs to breathe in by that time.

Adora's face has that soft, concerned look on it that has dominated her expressions lately and it makes some weak kind of anger bubble up in Catra's chest, but for once in her life, it can't find enough tinder to catch alight. Adora closes the door behind her, and Catra realizes she has something in her hand.

"Entrapta said you should clean your neck with this at the end of your shower to be safe. It's a really deep wound so we need to be extra careful," Adora says, lifting the bottle of antiseptic or whatever. Catra stares at it.

"Uncap it," she orders. Adora furrows her brow, but she does so. The moment the cap comes off, the astringent scent hits the air and Catra's ears pin back. Even Adora wrinkles her nose slightly as Catra instinctually hisses, though, putting the cap back in place.

"It's going to sting, but you've had way worse. I don't want you to get an infection now after everything," Adora offers. Catra hisses at her again. Adora holds the bottle out to her. Catra growls at her even as she reluctantly takes the bottle from her and eyes it skeptically.

"Couldn't She-ra just heal it for me?" she asks, glaring down at it.

"I'd rather not find out with an infection right next to your brain," Adora hums, rocking back and forth on her feet. Catra scowls. She looks up into the shower. She means to look for a shelf or nook or something that she can put the bottle on. Despite staring into it a lot, she hasn't actually *seen* it once.

She doesn't this time, either. She only becomes aware she froze when Adora moves closer and places a hand on her arm, startling her. Catra whips her head around, blinking up at her while Adora offers her an awkward smile.

"Hey, want me to stay?" she offers. Catra blinks at her several times. Her expression doesn't change.

"What?" she asks, voice a little hoarse. Adora offers her a small, self-conscious shrug.

"Well I know you always hated showers, and this one is going to hurt, so I just thought… I can just sit on top of the toilet. It's not any more uncomfortable than all the other rooms on this ship without chairs," Adora says. Catra stares at her. She honestly can't tell if Adora is offering her a nice lie or if she's clueless to what is actually sending Catra into a panic right now.

She mentioned the pool of green to Adora, when she asked how the chip happened, but she didn't really go into detail, and Adora never saw it, never saw that horrible, green expanse-

Adora's arms wrap around her and pull her into a hug. Catra shudders in her arms.

"Hey, I can help, too. I didn't really mean it when I said you stank this morning," Adora jokes, lightly. Catra manages a chuff, which isn't a laugh, but maybe it's good enough, because Adora doesn't let her go.

Despite Adora's assurances, empty or not, Catra's fur is uncomfortable, having far from received a shower when she got the chip, and certainly not since. She does need to shower.

It's just this first one. A terrible part of her is grateful for the pain, both for the distraction and for the extra support Adora is willing to offer her because of it.

"Okay," Catra manages to whisper, and she feels Adora's head jerk up.

“Oh! Great. Okay, I’m going to take my jacket off because it’s going to get a little steamy in here, but the water is like, the perfect kind of warm. The engine heats it, I think. Entrapta tried to explain it to me when I asked about the water filtration, but it was really complicated and I got lost,” Adora admits, arms slackening around her, and Catra reluctantly steps back so Adora can unclasp the pin holding her belt shut.

She holds her hand out. Adora stops in the middle of undoing her belt, looking down at it in confusion.

Catra doesn’t wait to be given the pin, instead taking it out of her hand and turning it over in her hand.

“Did you break this?” she asks, because the needle on the back looks like it isn’t attached right, and it’s a different color than the rest of the pin. Catra brushes her thumb over its length.

“Uh, yeah. A few times, actually. My belt wouldn’t stay in place without the Horde badge, and I was already having trouble adjusting to how different Bright Moon was, I didn’t want to change the clothes I had trained to fight it. This was just something Glimmer had that seemed like it might be able to do the job,” Adora explains. Catra chirps, turning the pin over again in her hand to look at the top of it. It’s a heavier metal than she expected, feeling like a solid cast piece. She thought gold was light, so this can’t all be gold.

“What is it?” Catra asks. Adora pauses and then resumes shedding her jacket.

“Remember Glimmer’s wings? I think you saw them at princess prom,” Adora says. Catra furrows her brow.

“I thought those were like, painted or something.” They were weird, she didn’t think much of them. They looked kind of like tattoos, but there’s no way Sparkles would have one of those, especially not at freshly eighteen. From the stories she has told Catra, her mom would kill her for that.

"No, they're like, magic birthmarks, or something. Her mom had wings, and instead they manifested as marks on Glimmer's shoulders. Her aunt gave her this and had this whole note with it about how she didn't need wings to fly and she had the marks to connect her with her mom but that she would always be bigger than that. I think. Glimmer turned it into a speech about how the Horde didn't define me, it got confusing. I don't think she ever liked the pin, though, she was never worried when it broke," Adora explains. Catra wrinkles her nose as she looks down at the pin again while Adora folds her jacket over her arm.

"You've been wearing Glimmer's dumb magic birthmark this whole time?" she asks. When she looks up, Adora is blushing a little.

"Well, I mean, yes, but wings represent Angella's family. It's part of their family crest. Oh, um, family crests are like a piece of art that represents your family. They usually have it hung on their wall somewhere – or wear it in a pin, like this!" Adora explains, waving at the pin.

Catra decides she doesn't want to hold it anymore and shoves it back into Adora's hand.

"Why?" she asks. Adora pauses. She opens her mouth. She closes it.

"So people know who your family is?" Adora offers. Catra scoffs, turning away. Bullshit, she doesn't know. She's then confronted with the empty shower and decides she's not done talking about this.

"So you've been wearing *Glimmer's* family crest? Wouldn't that defeat the purpose?" Catra asks, gaze locked on the shower. If she doesn't look away, it can't flood with green.

"It's just an element on the crest, but it was a way to show me that I had a place in Bright Moon. They do kind of feel like family, now. More than the Horde did, in general, but I… definitely missed some people from the Horde like family," Adora finishes in

a whisper. Catra's throat flexes, her tongue glued to the roof of her mouth and her jaw wired shut.

It turns out all she needed to shower was to want to be outside of it less. She steps in and Adora quickly steps back, moving to sit on the toilet seat where she can't see Catra as Catra strips with efficiency from her underwear and drops it on the ground outside the stall, slamming the door shut.

"I missed you, to be clear," Adora adds into the empty air, and Catra chokes on something that doesn't taste like the panic she was choking down earlier but feels like tears nonetheless. Immediately turning the water on full blast means she couldn't answer that if she wanted to.

The water hits her like the crunch of a broken bone, like the moment of cold weightlessness when the adrenaline kicks in and you can't feel the damage, like the numb flash of Shadow Weaver's lightning before it has drained from her body and reveals all the pain left in its wake. Her entire body locks up under the water. For a moment, she processes nothing, and then her body swears it feels colder than the Northern Reach, ice dragging her down and coating her body.

Suddenly heat flashes through her and her heart is beating again, warm water pouring down onto her shoulders. It's not as hot as she would normally want, but she thinks that kind of temperature difference might have killed her, so she stands, still trembling a little, under the warm water as it runs over her body and she realizes that she only started processing the world again when the water had made its way down her entire body so she could take stock of it. She'll never know if it was actually cold for a moment when she turned it on or not.

She breathes steadily, looking up at the top of the stall door. She doesn't think she closed her eyes at any point, but black flashed over her vision anyway. She can see now. She can hear now, the hiss of the shower battering against the walls of the bathroom.

“I missed you too,” Catra murmurs safely into the stream of the water. Adora doesn’t respond.

Catra shakes herself and reluctantly sets to scrubbing over her body with the limited supplies the shower provides.

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Catra is shaking under the water. Her body is cold again in the way that tells her she has been hit and needs to brace herself for the crash down, but nothing has changed, she’s just trying to scrub her hair, and water fell around her ears, and she *can’t breathe*, and she’s going to drown, she must have tipped back beneath the water by now, and Adora is just sitting there, silent while she drowns, drowns, d-

She falls to her knees in the shower, trembling, and the water pounds on her back.

“Catra?” Adora calls, so apparently the water isn’t as loud as it sounds in Catra’s ears. She struggles to breathe, body still locked up, and she doesn’t know what she would even say in response. It isn’t okay. It isn’t. She can’t breathe.

“Catra?” Adora asks again, voice closer. Catra quivers on the ground knowing Adora is standing just on the other side of the door, knowing she’s cornered and trapped and wants to run into her arms, and least of all her concerns, *naked*.

“Catra, I need you to respond or I’m opening this door,” Adora says, fast and assertive.

Apparently a whimper doesn’t count as a response. The door opens and Catra’s body flushes again, the heat of embarrassment breathing life back into her limbs. She curls around her knees, knowing Adora has seem much more of her in the past but still

ashamed of her bare back and getting Adora's arm wet as she reaches in to turn the water off for her.

The relentless pounding of the shower head is replaced with a quiet symphony of dripping, drops falling from Catra's ears, hair, tail, shoulders, and the showerhead itself, occasionally falling onto her back, each one sending small shocks through her like a blow.

"Okay, okay, one second," Adora promises her, no longer taking up the doorway for a moment, and then she's back and a towel is draping around Catra's shoulders. Catra reaches up to it with shaking hands, gathering it around herself and hating the noise of the edges falling around her to land in the wet puddles slowly trickling into the drain on the floor of the shower.

"There we go. Are you hurt?" Adora asks, hand gentle on her shoulder but it feels shakier than just Catra's rough breathing accounts for. Catra shakes her head. "Okay, you can take as long getting up as you need," Adora promises her. Catra suddenly pictures staying here, kneeled in the gathered water, or being *out*, out in the dry bathroom, and she's shooting to her feet on shaking feet, barely wrapping the towel around herself as she flees from the stall and straight into Adora. Adora, to her credit, adjusts and wraps her in a hug, practically pulling her over the edge of the shower stall.

"You did hear me say you could wait, right?" Adora jokes, but she hugs Catra, holding her close, and runs one hand down her back to soothe her as Catra breathes unsteadily in her arms. She's wet, and miserable, and the arms wrapped around her make her want to scream as much as they make her feel safe, but she can feel her body again. There isn't the cold of adrenaline or a foreign influence's control. She's soaking and wet and making *Adora* soaking and wet, but she feels like if Adora lets her go her throat will rip in half and another set of bruising hands will replace hers, so she presses forward into her arms and trembles there.

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Catra hisses, entire body tensing, as Adora holds the antiseptic-soaked cloth against her neck, gently cleaning the wound for any trapped water in her fur while Catra balls up on the floor of the bathroom, wrapped in a second towel, because the first one was so soaked it was making her skin crawl.

"It's healing really well. You won't have to do this for long," Adora promises her in a murmur as she dabs at it, pulling the cloth back to look it over and then dragging it over her neck one last time. Catra is too busy gritting her teeth to respond.

And yet it's not as bad as a regular shower, with regular water, in a regular stall.

"Good thing we're almost to Krytis and I'll hopefully never have to use that shitty shower again after we reach Etheria. It's too cold," Catra growls out as Adora dabs at her neck once more.

"The Horde showers were usually too close to scalding to feel nice, but everywhere else felt too cold in comparison at first. You'll get used to what the rest of the world considers to be a hot shower eventually," Adora promises her. Yeah, Catra doesn't think the cold had anything to do with the physical properties of the water, so that's not going to get better, but she doesn't voice that, instead tightening her fist wrapped around the knot in the towel as Adora completes one last wipe with her rag and then lowers it.

"Okay, it should be cleaned enough now. It didn't reopen or anything, so hopefully that dealt with any trapped moisture. I think Entrapta has a fresh change of clothes for you in your room," Adora says, standing and walking over to the sink to wring out the towel and wash her hands. Catra's gaze lifts to watch her as she dries her hands off on the regular rag that has been balled up on the edge of the sink ever since Catra first saw it.

"Entrapta?" she doesn't think she can wear anything Entrapta owns. She has a way bigger chest than her – thighs too, she *thinks*, though it's hard to tell under the overalls. Catra is *not* wearing overalls. She'll stick to Adora's underwear.

"Yeah, I saw her working on it, and she said she was going to try to have it ready. Let's go look," Adora offers, returning and holding out her hand. Catra looks at it and takes a deep breath, reluctantly putting her hand in Adora's and letting her pull her to her feet.

Adora doesn't let go as she walks her to her room.

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Catra isn't crying because she'll actually have a breakdown if she has to wash her face after all that, but she wants to. It's not Entrapta's clothes, or Adora's clothes, or even her clothes – it's *new* clothes, so familiar in their design like Adora's near-replica wardrobe of her Horde uniform, but the material is different from what they would use in the Horde, colors lighter and easier to stretch on. More supportive, too, which is good because "her" bra is currently soaking on the floor of the bathroom after she dripped everywhere. It fits her like it was custom made and she had no idea what kind of mental effect pulling on real clothes would have on her.

It's like she's waking up, becoming real again, becoming a *person* who wears clothes and interacts with society just like everyone else again. Maybe becoming a person for the first time. It makes it a little easier to breathe steadily when she looks up and Adora is grinning, giving her a thumbs up that has Catra blushing and ducking her head.

When her ears twitch back, they brush damp curls and there's a slight shiver through her body, but she suppresses it. She

showered. She's clean – enough. She got through it. She didn't drown, and Adora didn't even ask questions.

Adora was always telling the nice lie. She knew that was more than Catra's usual reaction to water, and that she was scared, and that Catra was exactly as weak as she thought she was.

Maybe that doesn't matter, when you have someone looking out for you.

Chapter End Notes

> So fun fact none of this is an exaggeration of how sensory aversion to water feels and there's a reason I write about Catra's experiences with water so much. I'm not scared of it, but I can't believe I didn't think I was autistic when I black out when water is splashed on me.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Have you ever wanted to read about someone washing their face in detail

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fighting for your life, constantly on the run, has a benefit. Catra is staring down a shower for the first time since stepping off Darla.

Adora's bathroom is completely foreign to Catra's concept of what bathrooms look like. It's small compared to the locker room, but far too large for one person. There are two sinks as if a second occupant was intended, but the bathroom is oversized for even that. Its tiles are a soft, rosy color and the lighting is warm and kind of *everywhere*, giving a glowing effect to the room. She has a tub, too, which Catra has rarely ever seen. She panicked the first time she saw it before she realized there was a shower at the end of the bathroom – it was so large she didn't recognize it at first – and she didn't ever have to touch the tub. There are towel racks holding more sizes of rags than she knows what to do with and a soft mat on the floor outside the shower. A mat Catra is standing on right now, staring into the empty tile box.

Adora explained how to turn on the hot water – because there's a cold option, which is new, considering the Fright Zone only had an "on" and that on was often near-scalding thanks to the steam pipes in the walls – but Catra can't seem to force herself to step inside. It should be easy. The shower is so different to what she's used to and so different from the pool, she doesn't know why she's having issues *now* when she managed to survive Mermista in the Fright Zone.

That was a fight, and it was far less vulnerable than this, standing naked in an unfamiliar, tiled, *cold* room. It's the idea of water going over her head, specifically, that's really getting to her, and

she *needs* to wash her hair, but that's going to feel like the last moment of breath before she fucking drowns and she just- she-

Melog is meowing and pawing at the door. She huffs, fisting her hands at her sides for a moment before she forces herself to reach forward and open up the stupid fancy glass door into the shower. Even when it's closed, it's like it's wide open, she's not trapped in *anything*. Especially because she still can't make herself step in the open doorway.

Melog smacks the door again, mewing plaintively. Catra zeroes in on the shower handle for the head on the end of the wall – because of course there are separate shower head on each end of the shower to make it easier to trap her in relentless waves. All she needs to do is walk over to that and turn it. It will be fine. She won't collapse again.

Melow mews. They don't seem so sure.

"Catra, are you okay?" Adora calls softly through the door. Fuck. Not again. She probably thinks she has collapsed again.

Catra doesn't feel that far off from it. Not while she's just standing here, but if she turns that water on? She could. The fear she will is why she can't move.

"Catra, I'm coming in," Adora decides. Oh. Right. Catra wraps her arms around herself, curling in on herself where she stands as Adora opens the door and draws to a halt. It's not like she hasn't seen Catra naked plenty, going all the way back to the shared locker room in the Horde with those horrible scalding showers.

"Oh," Adora breathes, which sounds worrying, and then she's quietly approaching. Catra hears cloth and the next thing she knows a towel is being wrapped around her from behind, gently covering her as Adora drops a light kiss to the back of her ear.

"You okay?" Adora asks, probably because she hasn't actually gotten as far as the water that makes her *not* okay this time. Catra nods. She's fine. She's just scared of not being fine.

“What do you need right now?” Adora asks as Melog mews again, loudly, and Catra finds out that Adora didn’t let them in with her. She doesn’t think she really has to worry about Melog seeing her naked. It’s just not the same to them. She swallows.

“Melog,” she decides. Adora turns her head to look back behind her as the doorknob *rattles*. Before Adora can let go of her, the door opens.

“They can do that?” Adora asks, her voice a little high with dawning horror. Catra snorts. It’s making her feel a little better.

“They can move stuff with magic now,” she says. Maybe they always could, but there wasn’t enough magic left out in space. Etheria makes it easy. Adora looks back at her as Melog pads forward and brushes against their sides, leaning against Catra’s legs and mewing softly. Catra absently reaches down, petting them as Adora keeps the towel wrapped around her.

“What else?” Adora asks. Catra’s gaze has started to swim on the tiles, but Melog is looking around the room for the first time and helping her to actually see it again. She swallows.

“To be clean,” she admits. She feels awful. She hasn’t had a proper shower since the Horde. Between the impromptu hair wash to get out the gel when she was still dazed from the rescue and the attempt at a shower on Darla, she was able to wash Horde Prime off, but she’d like a real, proper scrub. She’d like to feel like every inch of her is free of him, of the Fright Zone sewage, of the First Ones’ poison that spread through her veins, of her last three years and her entire past life while she’s at it. She’d like to shed everything she is – *including this fucking fear* – and come out the other side clean in a way that even Prime’s brainwashing pool could never achieve.

“Okay. We have options for that,” Adora says, hooking her chin over her shoulder. Catra makes a small, curious noise as Adora gathers the front of the towel in one hand so she can free the other to pet soothingly down Catra’s arm.

"You could shower. I could be in the room, or Melog could. I could bring a chair in here and read a book or something. I don't mind," Adora promises, pressing a kiss to the base of Catra's ear to illustrate her point. Catra blushes. She doesn't want to need help *showering*, she's not a fucking child.

"If the shower is too much, we can get a wet brush and towel and you can wash off that way. It's going to take a long time, though," Adora admits. Catra is suddenly overwhelmed and closes her eyes. Adora is so *sweet* and Catra is so stupid.

She never suggests the tub. Catra blows out a slow, steady breath.

"It's when it gets around my head that bothers me," she finally admits, breath shaking a little. Adora pauses. "My hair needs to be washed," she adds, because it really fucking does and she knows Adora's next suggestion would be skipping it. Adora thinks about it for a moment, petting down her arm.

"Why don't you take a normal shower from the neck down, and when you're ready, I can come in and wash your hair for you in the sink? I'll do what I can to keep it off your face and the rest of you can even be dressed at that point so it's less overwhelming," Adora offers.

Catra has no idea if it would work. She starts purring anyway, because she didn't do enough to deserve Adora and Adora likes her purr. She proves it when she wraps her free arm around her waist and hugs her.

"I think I'll get over it," Catra says.

"You don't have to today," Adora says, easy as anything. Catra's breath is shaking again for entirely not-shower related reasons.

She looks down at Melog. Melog looks up at her and mews softly.

"Okay, fine," she agrees with them, but Adora thinks she's talking to her, because she chuckles and drops a kiss against Catra's

cheek.

“You want me to stay or go?” she asks. Catra blows out a steady breath.

“You can go. I’ll call you when I’m ready. And Melog will call you if they need you,” she says, which is an impressive way to say *if I collapse on the floor of the shower again*, but Adora looks down at Melog.

“I’m here if you need me,” she tells them very solemnly and Catra maybe falls just a little bit more in love one heartbeat at a time. “I’ll be at my desk, okay?” Adora tells her, dropping a kiss to her shoulder as she leans back and Catra realizes she has to reach up to take control of the towel back from Adora so she can actually step away.

“Yeah,” Catra agrees. Adora squeezes Catra’s hand where it’s now fisting the front of the towel and then she steps back. She leaves the bathroom slowly, and then Catra’s alone with the shower, except she’s not.

She looks down at Melog. They don’t mind water in general, but they don’t like the idea of a shower right now either. They still mew to offer.

Catra scoffs and brushes past them, dropping the towel at the entry to the shower and reluctantly crossing over to the tap. She loses what remaining dignity she has by pinning herself against the wall so the water spray doesn’t hit her as it turns on, but she watches it begin running as Melog takes up guard next to the door – not in front of it, leaving her an open path out of the shower, but her heartrate feels so much steadier knowing the water isn’t going over her shoulders. She’ll hang back and use up Adora’s entire bar of soap if she has to. She is *getting* clean tonight.

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It’s amazing how much easier it is to shower when she just lets go of the idea of washing her hair. It’s amazing how much easier it *being* easy makes her breathing, because that means this is manageable even if she doesn’t get over it tonight.

She feels like she’s in the shower forever and uses half of Adora’s bar of soap, but it’s weirdly soft anyway, and she’s due for the longest shower of her life. She might get truly clean of the first time. It only makes her oily hair feel even more unpleasant in contrast as she dries her body off. She calls for Adora as she pulls on the pajamas sitting on the counter, which are silky soft and as foreign to her as the massive shower. Adora is there almost before Catra can finish changing, and she breaks into a grin when she looks Catra over and apparently doesn’t find a visible sign of a breakdown.

“How was it?” she asks, dragging the chair from her desk into the bathroom. Catra flinches as it scrapes on the tile.

“I still hate water, but I missed being clean,” she admits.

“Have you washed your face?” Adora asks as she nudges the chair in front of the closer sink. Catra’s ears pin back.

“No,” she begrudgingly admits. That’s water on her head. She wasn’t ready for that even with Melog watching. It’ll be… easier now, outside of the shower and fully dressed.

She hopes.

“Do you want to try that yourself?” Adora asks, neutrally, like there’s no shame in Catra being too pathetic to wash her own face. She takes a deep breath.

“Yeah,” she agrees, stepping around the chair to the other sink. Adora doesn’t hover, thankfully, instead going to the shower to collect the hair products. Catra turns on the sink and takes a deep breath, looking down.

Her hands are still damp from the shower when she cups them under the faucet. She lets it pool up in her palms. That's fine. Like, she hates it, but she knows the range of the "hate" scale is much higher than she thought was possible before all this so it is, relatively, *fine*. She parts her hands and lets most of the water slip away before lifting her hands and running them over her cheeks. She wrinkles her nose. She hates it.

She hates it the normal amount. She reluctantly lets her hands fill with water again and ducks her head this time so she can properly wash her jaw and neck, working up to it. It's deeply unpleasant, slimy in a way she knows water isn't actually, sending an cold shiver through her body, all of it uncomfortable but entirely normal. Melog mews at her, sitting down next to her and sniffing at the edge of the sink. Catra growls her way through washing the rest of her face.

There's a brief moment where she feels a cold shiver down her spine as she washes her forehead, but then Melog gives a low, reverberating mew and Catra manages to force her eyes open, quickly wiping the water away and looking up to find Adora looking up from where she's rolling rags up at the edge of the counter for some reason and forming a moat around the sink. Adora's brow furrows, and her lips part like she's about to speak, but Catra looks away.

Adora has a lot of rags and she won't miss the one Catra grabs from the edge of her weird fort, running it under the water in silence to soak it. When it feels saturated, she switches to using that to scrub her face.

That's both worse, tugging at her fur painfully, and way better because it can't possibly drown her. She decides to finish the rest of her face that way, awkwardly rubbing a bar of soap into the towel to help get all the oil off of her, but eventually her fur has been tugged at too much and she thinks she only still feels dirty because her hair is a mess. She leans back from the mirror, flushes at how messy she looks, and turns to look at Adora, who smiles encouragingly at her.

"I made you a pillow for when you're ready. Just sit down and lean back," she offers. Catra arches a brow at the ring of towels.

"*That's* what it's supposed to be?" she asks as she nervously sits in the chair and leans back.

Adora leans down and kisses her, which promptly shuts up any complaints and the anxious rise of her heartrate.

"Bright Moon has people who train to cut your hair. They use them when they wash your hair. I'm giving you a *premium* experience," Adora tells her, dragging out premium in a way that just sounds like she's mispronouncing it but makes Catra giggle because she's laughing at Adora being a dumbass, obviously. Watching Adora plug the sink kills it in her throat, though. She needs another distraction.

"Why do you need to train to hold scissors? Do princesses have to make everything complicated?" Catra asks as she leans back and is immediately surprised to find those hair trainees may be onto something because the towel cushions her neck well as she tips her head back into the sink.

"They have techniques and stuff and know how to translate what you're describing into the style you actually want on your head. It's normal outside of the Horde," Adora explains as she turns the sink on. Catra tenses. Adora runs her fingers through her hair and Catra tries to be relaxed by it, but she knows what's coming. "I'm going to try to be fast, okay?" Adora tells her. Catra reluctantly nods as she swears she feels the water lapping at the back of her head.

Adora gathers the water in her hands in much the same way Catra did to wash her face and tips it over the back of her head, missing her bangs entirely, but Catra would rather *this* part be slow. Adora cards her wet fingers through her hair again and Catra feels a cold shiver down her spine.

She remembers those hands on her as they chopped her mane. It's all she can remember as Adora wets her hair, but then her hands leave her to grab the shampoo. The water isn't pleasant, but Adora shuts off the running water before it can reach her ears.

"I'm going to do your ears last, okay?" Adora tells her. Catra suddenly feels silly and childish again hearing Adora say it, but then her hands are massaging the shampoo in her hair and that's… kind of nice, actually. Adora's touch is soothing and pleasant and nothing like the one she was remembering for a second there. Maybe this isn't so bad.

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She still hates the water, and sometimes panic flutters in her throat when Adora gently pours water over the crown of her head, but mostly Adora's fingers are massaging product in and then out of her hair, and that's nice when she ignores everything else.

"Is this weird?" Catra asks, having to blurt out a distraction when Adora opens the sink drain so she can turn the tap on again and get clean water. Adora glances down at her.

"I tackled you in the shower, like, five years ago. We wrestled naked on the floor and everything. I'd say this is pretty normal compared to what we used to do," Adora says, causing Catra to blush severely, because she remembers that in *vivid* detail and it was definitely more than five years ago based on Adora's boob size at the time, but it doesn't really matter when it happened because it was both a fantasy and a nightmare regardless.

It was definitely weirder than what they're doing now even if it felt like a natural conclusion to their banter at the time.

“We got in trouble for that,” Catra points out. Adora rolls her eyes as her fingers run through Catra’s hair again.

“We got in trouble for everything. We’d get in trouble for this too. That doesn’t make it wrong,” Adora says, fingers running behind Catra’s ears, and somehow that simple statement also makes Catra blush.

She’s just not used to the idea. She’s used to living in fear of everything. She thinks when she’s past expecting punishment to come any moment, she’ll be past expecting to be pulled into a memory every time she steps beneath the water, and expecting it is where the fear comes from.

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Catra slinks out of the bathroom with a towel wrapped around her head and hisses at Adora when she looks up from her desk and her lips twitch.

She’s getting used to Bright Moon. She’s getting used to this supposed “safety” thing and she at least has had time to process that Prime is dead even if she does keep expecting some new warlord to appear, but she still needs little things to help her and the hair towel to keep water from dripping down her neck is one of those. Adora has also spent a lot of time with her hands in Catra’s hair and it’s helped her get passed the mental block she had when first stepping into the shower.

It helps that she has gotten products meant for her mane and not the same silky shit Adora uses for her own hair. It makes her feel good enough when she gets out of the shower that she can force herself through it. It holds up better, too, so if it’s a bad day she can always just skip washing her hair, and knowing she can do that makes it a lot easier to get in the shower in first place. Once she’s already there, it’s easier to just finish and do it right.

Normally it's fine, but she seems to find new ways to backslide all the time and today she barely made it. She stalks past Adora and throws herself onto the lounge with a huff. Adora turns her chair at her desk to watch her, eyes skating over her.

"You okay?" Adora asks as Catra's tail twitches in a way that clearly communicates to her she isn't. Catra huffs, tilting her head back on the arm of the lounge so she can glare at the ceiling instead of her girlfriend.

"I haven't had to skip washing my hair for *weeks* and suddenly today I couldn't do my ears," she complains. Adora stands from her chair to walk over and offer her moral support, which is annoying, and Catra scowls at her to convey it. "I thought I was past this!" It sucks and she wants to complain, but she doesn't want to be so weak she needs *comfort* over it. It's already weak enough that she's like this.

Adora sits down and pets the top of her head towel, and it's so comical she has to laugh even though she can't feel it at all. She reaches up and bats at Adora's hand. Adora smiles as she lowers her hand to instead cup her face. Catra immediately stops fighting, blinking up at her. It's so stupid how Adora just smiling down at her softly is enough to make her eyes relax and a small purr start in the back of her throat as Adora's thumb gently strokes her cheek. Catra has spent her entire life chasing a touch like this – chasing *this* touch, exactly.

"It doesn't matter, you know that, right? You can take as long as you need getting there, you don't need to push yourself for nothing. If you can't wash your ears sometimes it isn't hurting anything. I'm still going to kiss them," Adora tells her, and then she demonstrates her point by leaning down and kissing the bridge of her nose like she sometimes does because she's weird but Catra can't imagine anyone but Adora finding that romantic, so she finds it romantic because she's a fucking goner. She still tries to scowl as Adora pulls back.

"I don't care. I have all these… fucking *hangups* I never used to have and even when they're getting better, they're getting more annoying. I'm sick of skipping it, I'm sick of flinching when someone touches my shoulder, I'm sick of having a panic attack every time I see Scorpia use her powers," Catra complains. Adora looks at her for a long moment and then her hand steadily drags down and Catra flushes as Adora's hand sweeps over her shoulder, feeling it out so purposefully it almost feels indecent even though it's completely innocent.

"Shut up, you know that's different." First of all, she could see Adora was about to do it. Second of all, it's Adora. Catra just feels a certain way about Adora's hands and it's harder for her to fear them – she still does, sometimes, but that's more scary than annoying.

"So is your reaction to Scorpia. When it goes from scary to just irritating is a good sign," Adora says. Catra groans.

"But it's *annoying*," she reiterates like Adora didn't just say that. Adora pauses, looking at her for a long moment, and then two, and then Catra starts to feel self-conscious, her tail flicking. Eventually, Adora's hand trails down and she takes up Catra's hand.

"Annoyance is kind of a Bright Moon thing. In the Horde, you *had* to be scared. I- I had to. And then in Bright Moon, you start to discover hangups you never knew you had, because you weren't allowed to have them, right? It was too dangerous there, but it gets better. They go away," Adora says, fumbling in the way she only does when she's talking about herself, and Catra blinks up at her.

Adora is using none of the right words – barely coherent words at all – for what Catra is really feeling, but at the same time, she understands it. Adora wasn't fighting for survival the same way Catra was, but she still was in her *own* way, and she was still going through the hellish regime and pressure there – the one Catra is still expecting when she feels a hand land on her

shoulder. It's safe to have those feelings in Bright Moon instead of shoving them down, so it's a new sensation, prickly on her skin and irritating, but mild compared to the fear that wouldn't let her flinch when she needed to before.

It's kind of a privilege to be annoyed instead of scared. Catra huffs, reaching down for Adora's hand and pulling it back up to her face. Adora smiles, fond, and goes back to petting her cheek as her other hand finds Catra's instead.

"It'll get better, and you can complain until then," she promises.

Oh, Catra *will*, but that knowledge makes it a little easier to stomach for now.

Chapter End Notes

> One of the first fics I tried to write for She-ra was something called "in waterfalls" and it was all about showering, which sounds crazy, but you've just read how I can go on about showers for 7k, so indulge me.
> To my memory, this fic was just going to be scenes of their showers over the years. The first was when they were kids in the Horde, tackling each other and playing around. I know another scene was going to be Adora figuring out how to work her Bright Moon shower and feeling lonely and adrift in it. Another would have been Catra's first shower in Bright Moon. I wasn't happy with how the fic was going and didn't get very far into it, so I just chucked it in my "abandoned" folder and I ended up treading all the ground I wanted to cover with it in other fics. I think in "return from civility" I talked a little bit about showers, and either in that fic or another I included Catra's journey with shower products and how she eventually came around to showers just because Bright Moon's were better, but it turns out I wanted to get deeper into it lol, so here it is. It might conflict with some things I said in other OOTW fics because I've been working on this series for five years and I don't remember the things I've said by this point LOL in which case, definitely take this

fic as the “non-canon” one, but it’s something I wanted to explore more.
This is probablyyyyyy my last post for February because I’m going to be travelling through the end of the month, and I’ll be working on a Pokemon fic mostly in that time, but once it’s done……. Patchwork is finally on the docket.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!